

GETTY IMAGES

THE VANDE BHARAT CRAWL

180 KMPH Capable speed

160 KMPH Permitted speed

76 KMPH Average speed

HOW THE WORLD MOVES

Trains built for 200 kmph typically average 120-160

Capable speed | Average speed

CHINA: *D-series*

200-250 KMPH | **140-180** KMPH

(Mixed-use 200 kmph lines average 140-150 kmph)

GERMANY *Intercity lines*

200 KMPH | **120-150** KMPH

(Fewer halts push averages higher)

UK: *Intercity lines*

200 KMPH | **120-145** KMPH

(The InterCity 125 historically clocked 130-140 kmph on long runs)



"Speeding up trains above 150 kmph is fraught with safety issues. You need fenced tracks, automatic signalling, anti-collision devices, grade separators and automated maintenance"

MOHAMMAD JAMSHED, *Former Member (Traffic), Railway Board; Distinguished Fellow, Chintan Research Foundation*

Why the Slowdown?

The reason is that track technology and upgrades never kept pace. More than 90 per cent of India's railway network tops out at 110 kmph (see *Why the Drag*). Curves, gradients, bridges—the system was never built for speed. Despite years of upgrades and announcements, not one corridor is ready to run 160 kmph from end to end. Schedules are riddled with pauses. Maintenance means perpetual short-notice restrictions—gangmen squatting next to the rails as a Vande Bharat snails through. And with freight trains and slow passenger services using the same lines, congestion strangles even the speediest. Railway data analysed by INDIA TODAY shows how speed limits turn journeys into jagged sections of acceleration and braking. On the Gwalior-Jhansi stretch, for instance, the Vande Bharat can reach its top speed of 130 kmph on just over half the route, otherwise it settles for 94-97 kmph.

Data show that as of end of March 2025, the rail network had around 17,000 speed restrictions of one kind or another. More

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